

32 Future possibilities

There are many ways to talk about imaginary future situations. Different structures can be used to indicate whether a situation is likely or unlikely.

See also:

Present simple **1** Past simple **7**

Past perfect simple **13**

32.1 LIKELY FUTURE POSSIBILITIES

"What if" or "suppose" followed by the present tense can be used to express a future outcome that is likely to happen.

"What if" means "what would happen if an imagined situation occurred?"

What if
Suppose

I **fail** my exams? I won't be able to go to college.

Present tense shows the speaker believes this is likely to happen.

"Suppose" refers to the consequences of an imagined situation.



FURTHER EXAMPLES

What if the computer **crashes**?
I will lose all my work.

Suppose they **assess** our coursework.
We will have to keep a portfolio.

32.2 UNLIKELY FUTURE POSSIBILITIES

"What if" or "suppose" followed by the past simple can be used to express a future outcome that is possible, but unlikely to happen.

Just imagine! **What if**
Suppose we all **got** 100% on our exams?

The past tense shows the speaker thinks this is unlikely to happen.



FURTHER EXAMPLES

Suppose I **got caught** cheating.
My parents would be furious.

What if our flight **was canceled**?
We'd be stuck here!